

The Waterfront Brief

This issue covers four stories and six things to watch. The first asks why destroyer modernization periods are landing on time when almost nothing else in depot maintenance does, and what the answer costs. The second follows a tank inspection camera from three regional maintenance centers to all seven. The third reads two submarine docks at Puget Sound changing state in the same month. The fourth reports that the expeditionary repair capacity No. 2 said to watch has been packed into a container.

Labels: FACT is attributed to the named source in the same sentence; Assessment is this desk’s analysis, built only on facts stated above it; Speculation is flagged as such; Unverified marks a claim this desk could not check against a primary source, with the reason given.

OPERATIONS MAINTENANCE &
READINESS

Destroyer modernization periods are landing on time, and the reason is the shape of the job

Two destroyers came out of their modernization periods early this summer, and the programme behind them says it has been on time eleven times out of twelve. The reason is that the Navy made the job smaller and gave it one owner, and both halves matter to anyone who plans an availability.

FACT: the Navy announced on June 26, 2026 that USS Chung-Hoon (DDG 93) and USS James E. Williams (DDG 95) had completed Depot Modernization Periods under the DDG Modernization 2.0 programme, with General Dynamics NASSCO as the lead maintenance activity and the Mid-Atlantic and Southwest Regional Maintenance Centers as the Navy supervisory activities, per the NAVSEA release carried by DVIDS. The lead maintenance activity does the work; the supervisory activity is the Navy office that oversees it. FACT: Naval News reported the same day that both ships were accepted ahead of schedule. A Depot Modernization Period is a scheduled availability whose main purpose is installing new equipment rather than repairing old.

The eleven-of-twelve figure is older than those deliveries. FACT: Vice Adm. John Gumbleton said at the Combined Naval Event in June 2025 that “in [the new] construct, we have been on time 11 of 12 times, and the one outlier was two weeks late,” and that the

Navy had “made the conscious decision to prioritize predictability over deferring modernization,” per Naval News’s June 2026 report of the remark. FACT: Naval News’s account of that keynote records that the approach grew out of the Ticonderoga cruiser experience, puts a single accountable individual in charge, and uses two 150-day periods.

FACT: USNI News reported in January 2025 that the first four ships, Pinckney, James E. Williams, Chung-Hoon and Halsey, receive the upgrade in two availability phases, the SLQ-32(V)7 electronic warfare suite first, after which Capt. Moore said they serve in the fleet “for some time” before a second Depot Modernization Period installs the SPY-6 radar, and that USS Sterett will be the first to take the whole package in a single availability “within the next five years.” FACT: Naval News’s June 2026 description puts the radar in the second step for all four, with the first step complete on three and under way on Halsey. FACT: USNI News reported in January 2023 that a Navy official put the time to install all three systems on a ship at 18 to 24 months.

The construct exists because the last modernization programme failed. That programme was the cruisers. The plan was to take the Ticonderoga-class cruisers out of service in turn, rebuild each one over four years, and return them to the fleet. FACT: GAO reported in 2025 that the Navy planned to modernize eleven cruisers and now expects to return only three, per GAO-25-106749. FACT: the same report says the five cruisers that reached their modernization periods cost about \$881 million more than the planned \$2.44 billion, a 36 percent increase, and that each ran three to nearly five years past its four-year plan. Every cruiser that started was late. Under DDG MOD 2.0, on Gumbleton’s count, the worst destroyer was two weeks late. Attack submarines are the other reference point, because they are the Navy’s other large depot programme and the one this brief has followed. FACT: GAO reported in August 2026 that the public shipyards completed about 11 percent of attack submarine depot maintenance on time from fiscal years 2016 through 2025, per GAO-26-109256, the report No. 7 covered.

The construct is not the only way to a date, and the government yards are naming their own mechanics. FACT: SRF-JRMC in Yokosuka delivered USS Preble (DDG 88) on schedule on August 24 after an

approximately \$33 million maintenance and modernization package, per the command's DVIDS release of September 9; NAVSEA describes that command as "a medium-sized, full-service, non-nuclear naval shipyard," per its page on working in Japan. FACT: Pearl Harbor Naval Shipyard undocked USS Illinois on June 24 after "front-loading key milestones to significantly speed up the final pier-side certification process," with the project supervisor, Gilbert Gould, saying that "by maximizing productivity and testing in dry dock, the project is on track to complete the shortest end game that the shipyard has performed to date," per NAVSEA's July 7 release; the yard then undocked USS North Carolina on time on August 12, per its August 12 release. The end game is the pier-side testing and certification that follows undocking.

Assessment: what DDG MOD 2.0 changed is not the yards or the trades but the size of the promise. The first period carries the electronic warfare suite and the cooling for what comes later; the radar, the largest part of a package USNI's 2023 figure says takes up to two years to install, has not been installed on any of the four two-step ships. Eleven of twelve is a count of the small periods. The prediction is that the rate falls when the radar periods begin, because replacing a ship's main sensor is a job the size of a cruiser rebuild, and that it does not fall to the cruiser record, because the two things the Navy says it changed after the cruisers, scope fixed before the ship arrives and one person who owns the whole job, are the two things that decide whether a period ends on its date.

Bottom line: plan the next availability as a fixed-length block with its scope locked before the ship arrives, put growth that is not safety or certification into a defined later period, and ask which pier-side tests could move into the dock phase; a DDG MOD 2.0 hull at your pier between periods carries a pending radar period, so ask the planning yard which step it is in before the package is written.

Sources: NAVSEA via DVIDS, Jun 26, 2026; Naval News, Jun 26, 2026; Naval News, Jun 1, 2025; USNI News, Jan 16, 2025; USNI News, Jan 31, 2023; GAO-25-106749; GAO-26-109256; SRF-JRMC via DVIDS, Sep 9, 2026; NAVSEA, SRF-JRMC Yokosuka description; NAVSEA, Jul 7, 2026; NAVSEA, Aug 12, 2026

Puget Sound this month: one submarine dock back, one about to empty

Two of the three submarine docks at Bremerton that the Navy closed on earthquake risk in 2023 change state this month, and that moves the queue for every attack boat waiting on the West Coast.

FACT: USNI News reported on January 27, 2023 that the Navy had temporarily closed four docks used to overhaul nuclear submarines in Washington, three at

Puget Sound Naval Shipyard and Intermediate Maintenance Facility and the delta pier at the Trident Refit Facility in Bangor, after finding them at risk of earthquake damage. FACT: the Navy announced on August 28, 2026 that it marked completion of the Dry Dock 4 seismic retrofit on August 26, that the original scope ran five months ahead of schedule, that One Big Beautiful Bill Act funds took the contract from \$377.7 million to \$517 million for added work, and that modeling cut the anchors needed from an estimated 1,000 to 600. FACT: the same release says the added funds paid to remove 500 decommissioned keel blocks, giving the yard laydown space.

The other dock has held one boat for three years. FACT: NAVSEA told Naval News in August 2023 that USS Connecticut (SSN 22) was in Dry Dock 5 at Puget Sound in an Extended Docking Selected Restricted Availability, docked on July 12, 2023. FACT: a Navy spokesperson told The War Zone in July 2025 that the availability formally began in February 2023, that the October 2021 grounding damage was being repaired inside it, and that the boat was expected back in late 2026; the same report notes the Navy had told Naval News in March 2023 that the availability was "notionally sized at 31 months." FACT: the New Haven Register reported on June 1, 2026 that the boat was expected to resume service in September, and that the Navy's shipbuilding plan published in May set a 2031 retirement date, which that plan lists as recycling in 2031, per the Navy's May 2026 long-range shipbuilding plan. An Extended Docking Selected Restricted Availability is a submarine's deepest scheduled maintenance short of an overhaul; the collision repair was folded into it.

Assessment: Bremerton gains submarine docking capacity twice in one quarter, a retrofitted dock on August 26 and, if the Register's September date holds, an emptied one after 38 months with a single hull in it against a plan of 31. The prediction is that a docking is moved earlier at Puget Sound this autumn, that the attack boat which had been waiting pier-side moves first, and that GAO's idle-day count, 3,454 days across fiscal 2021 to 2025, shows the change only in fiscal 2027 data, because the days already lost are booked. The risk is that the two docks arrive together, so two dockings' worth of pre-docking work lands on the same planning staff at once.

Bottom line: if your shop feeds Puget Sound, whether from the Northwest RMC, the Everett detachment or a contractor, expect two dockings' worth of pre-docking work in the same window this autumn and staff the planning side before the hulls move; and take the keel-block lesson home, because 500 idle blocks were laydown space the yard did not know it had.

Sources: USNI News, Jan 27, 2023; U.S. Navy, Aug 28, 2026; Naval News, Aug 8, 2023; The War Zone, Jul 15, 2025; New Haven Register via CT OMA, Jun 1, 2026; Navy long-range shipbuilding plan, May 2026; GAO-26-109256

MAINTENANCE ENGINEERING & TECHNOLOGIES

The tank you never enter: a camera on a stalk is going to all seven regional maintenance centers

A tank inspection tool that keeps people out of the tank is being fielded across the surface fleet's maintenance centers this fiscal year, and the gain is in planning before it is in safety.

FACT: the Naval Research Laboratory said on May 29, 2026 that it has fielded the next generation of its Insertable Stalk Inspection System, ISIS360, a non-entry inspection technology that is "collapsing inspection timelines from days or weeks to hours," and that it is working with Commander, Navy Regional Maintenance Center to expand it to seven regional maintenance centers in fiscal 2026, per the laboratory's DVIDS release. FACT: the same release says tank inspections were historically done on a fixed interval, with the tank emptied, cleaned and prepared for entry regardless of condition, that entry required a gas-free certificate, lighting and scaffolding, and that aboard USS America in March 2025, 64 tanks were inspected, 49 of them with ISIS360, in many cases without gas-free certification or entry. A gas-free certificate is the sign-off that a confined space is safe to enter, and getting one is a scheduled evolution with its own people.

FACT: NRL says the system's algorithm returns the percentage of surface corroded, that a fuel-safe configuration inspects fuel tanks without emptying them, and that results export to the Surface Maintenance Engineering Planning Program, SURFMEPP. FACT: SURFMEPP "provides centralized life cycle maintenance engineering, as well as class maintenance and modernization planning" for surface ships, per GAO-25-106990. FACT: NRL's corrosion branch head, Ted Lemieux, said "the real savings come in improved planning," preventing "surprises that turn into schedule delays."

FACT: Southeast RMC said on May 7, 2026 that it fielded ISIS360 on USS Iwo Jima in April 2025, imaging 31 tanks, that it had used the original ISIS "about 10 years ago," and that Mid-Atlantic RMC led the effort, per the command's DVIDS release. FACT: SRF-JRMC said on July 9, 2026 that NRL and CNRMC delivered the system to Yokosuka and Sasebo in May, that its corrosion control branch head, Kouji Koizumi, called it "permanently adopted," and that "significant

defects still require a follow-up human-entry assessment," which he called "relatively rare"; the release's photo caption shows a locally built grating over the void opening so the stalk goes in without a fall hazard.

Assessment: the tool changes the question from "which tanks are due" to "which tanks failed the camera," and that moves the tank line of a work package from the availability into the window before it. It is a coating and corrosion tool; nothing in the releases says it gauges plate thickness, so structural condition still needs entry or ultrasonic testing. The prediction is that centers which run the camera pier-side before the package locks see their tank scope shrink and their gas-free schedule compress within a year, and that the availabilities which still grow from tank findings are at yards that run it after arrival.

Bottom line: run the camera during continuous maintenance or the pier-side window before the availability, not on day one of it, so the tanks that fail are in the package and the tanks that pass are out of it; build the grating fixture before the equipment arrives, and size the gas-free and entry team for the fails rather than for every tank.

Sources: NRL via DVIDS, May 29, 2026; SERMC via DVIDS, May 7, 2026; SRF-JRMC via DVIDS, Jul 9, 2026; GAO-25-106990

WATERFRONT OPS & PRODUCTION

The expeditionary repair capacity No. 2 said to watch has been packed into a container

The mobile repair capability this brief flagged in July now exists as a loaded container with a 72-hour standard attached to it, and the first rehearsal on the Pacific side was in April.

FACT: SIMA Norfolk said on July 22, 2026 that its sailors loaded a container with industrial plant equipment, piping, metal stock and other material for transport to the 6th Fleet area to support an Expeditionary Repair Availability during the Ship Wartime Repair and Maintenance Exercise scheduled for August, that the work supports the Navy's Expeditionary Maintenance and Repair Container initiative to pre-stage standardized repair packages, and that "the long-term objective is to position expeditionary maintenance capabilities that can arrive within 72 hours," per the command's DVIDS release. A Shore Intermediate Maintenance Activity is the sailor-manned repair shop at a homeport, one level below a depot; an Expeditionary Repair Availability is a repair period outside the maintenance plan.

FACT: U.S. Pacific Fleet said on April 4, 2026 that USS Ashland completed a Ship Wartime Repair and Maintenance Exercise in the Philippines, with the

ship's commanding officer, Cmdr. Adam Peebles, describing "complex repairs" conducted "shoulder-to-shoulder with our Philippine allies" while the ship stayed ready to respond. No. 2 closed its battle-damage article with the line that "the near-term moves worth watching are mobile and expeditionary repair capacity and firm allied-yard agreements."

Assessment: the container is a shop leaving its building, and the 72-hour standard is a packing list before it is a skills problem. Results from the August exercise are not published, so nothing here says the standard was met. The prediction is that the next container announced is a Pacific one, because the April rehearsal was in 7th Fleet and the Atlantic exercise now has a template, and that the first argument it produces is about which qualified people go with it.

Bottom line: list the machines and the qualifications in your shop that would have to leave with a container, and write down what the shop cannot do for the weeks they are gone; that list is the expeditionary plan, and it is also the case for a second machine.

Sources: *SIMA Norfolk via DVIDS, Jul 22, 2026; U.S. Pacific Fleet, Apr 4, 2026; The Waterfront Brief No. 2*

Six things to watch

Six developments that are not yet stories.

FACT: the August 13 presidential memorandum directs a plan, due within 90 days, to establish a Component Repair Center "to receive new and refurbish old components and parts as required by the submarine repair industrial base," holding at least one ship set of spares for five submarine classes, per the White House text. That puts the plan at about November 11.

FACT: the President signed H.R. 6500 on September 2, a continuing resolution funding the government through December 11, 2026, per the White House. FACT: Inside Defense reported that it keeps spending largely at fiscal 2026 levels while letting the Navy obligate nearly \$2.61 billion above that rate for cost growth on ships already under contract, and section 126 of the enrolled text lists those lines by programme, the largest being \$566,542,000 for Columbia-class submarines, \$561,131,000 for Virginia-class submarines and \$379,200,000 for carrier refueling overhauls. No line covers ship maintenance.

FACT: The Korea Times reported on September 10 that DAPA vice minister Kim Il-dong said Korean

shipbuilders have won 12 US Navy maintenance contracts since 2024, five this year, and that "MRO is not an end in itself, but a gateway" to combat-vessel maintenance and shipbuilding. FACT: Naval News reported on September 10 that Mitsubishi Heavy Industries' existing commitments leave it "very limited spare capacity" to support a US frigate build, and The Maritime Executive reported on September 1 that HD Hyundai's Ulsan yard entered its fourth consecutive year of strikes.

FACT: The Maritime Executive reported on September 7 that Austal confirmed talks with a US investment firm, Wildcat Infrastructure, and later that Austal's September 9 filing put Wildcat's non-binding indication at \$1.25 to \$1.35 billion enterprise value, against Hanwha's earlier offer.

FACT: Michael Cadenazzi, assistant secretary of war for industrial base policy, told a House appropriations field hearing on September 4 that the defense industrial base has about 400,000 unfilled skilled-trade jobs, a figure that could reach 2.5 million within a decade, per DoD News on September 8.

Assessment: decide which component work you would keep before the center names a site; under the CR, ship maintenance runs at last year's rate through the first quarter of the year No. 8 said would need more; Korea's count is the allied-capacity number to plan against, and Japan's answer is why the count is Korea's; the Austal story runs when a binding offer exists; and the trades figure is national, so read it as the pool your pipeline draws from, not your gap.

Bottom line: put November 11 and December 11 on the calendar, settle before the first which component refurbishment stays in-house, and expect no new maintenance money before the second.

Sources: *White House, Aug 13, 2026; White House, Sep 3, 2026; Inside Defense, Sep 2026; H.R. 6500, enrolled; The Korea Times, Sep 10, 2026; Naval News, Sep 10, 2026; The Maritime Executive, Sep 1, 2026; The Maritime Executive, Sep 7, 2026; The Maritime Executive, Sep 2026; DoD News via GlobalSecurity, Sep 8, 2026*

The Waterfront Brief is compiled weekly by the B2 vault's research engine from primary sources and verified trade reporting. Scope: US shipbuilding, US Navy sustainment, and partners across the Indo-Pacific region; out-of-area items only when there is a direct, stated lesson. Freshness policy: every article's anchor source is under 12 months old; older material appears only as dated context or a flagged exception. FACT means the named source says it, not that this desk has independently verified it. Corrections welcome; staged sources are retained for audit.

UPCOMING EVENTS

Nearest first, filling the page. **Bold** marks a decision that closes inside the next 60 days. ASNE is the American Society of Naval Engineers; NSRP is the National Shipbuilding Research Program, the industry-Navy body that funds shared shipyard process research; SCA is the Shipbuilders Council of America.

Dates	Event	Register by	Why it matters
Sep 22-24, 2026	FMMS 2026 (Fleet Maintenance & Modernization Symposium), Virginia Beach, VA (ASNE)	Open; early bird closed Aug 16	Maintenance execution / regional capacity: the maintenance community's own event; NSRP's Sustainment Panel meets there Sep 23, free
Oct 20-21, 2026	NSRP Workforce & Compliance and Production Planning Joint Panel, Pensacola, FL (NSRP)	Open, no deadline	Workforce and production-planning panels meet jointly; in person or virtual
Nov 12-13, 2026	Naval Submarine League Annual Symposium 2026, Arlington, VA (NSL)	To be posted	Submarine industrial base: the submarine force and its builders and repairers set the year's priorities
Dec 8-11, 2026	Department of War Maintenance Symposium 2026, Fort Lauderdale, FL (SAE for DoW)	Open, no deadline	Maintenance execution: the department-wide depot maintenance meeting; maintenance awards and cross-service policy
Jan 12-14, 2027	SNA National Symposium 2027, Arlington, VA (SNA)	Not yet open	Programme priorities: where the surface force states modernization and maintenance priorities; DDG MOD 2.0 news lands here
Jan 26-28, 2027	Military Additive Manufacturing Summit (MILAM), Tampa, FL (DSI)	Next tier closes Oct 2 ; final Jan 22	Additive qualification: defense additive qualification and NAVSEA-spec adoption
Feb 16-18, 2027	WEST 2027, San Diego, CA (AFCEA/USNI)	Not printed	Programme priorities: the Pacific-side sea services conference; West Coast fleet maintenance sessions
Mar 23-25, 2027	NSRP All Panel Meeting 2027, North Charleston, SC (NSRP)	"Coming soon"	Regional capacity: where yard R&D ideas get teamed programme-wide
Apr 4-7, 2027	Sea-Air-Space 2027, National Harbor, MD (Navy League)	Open, no deadline	Programme priorities: the largest US maritime defense exposition; the Navy states programme priorities
Apr 11-15, 2027	AMPP Annual Conference + Expo 2027, Columbus, Ohio (AMPP)	Abstracts due Oct 1 ; best rate from Sep 14	Preservation: the corrosion and coatings profession's main event; preservation is the highest-volume trade
Jun 8-10, 2027	MegaRust 2027, Hampton, VA (ASNE)	Not yet open; exhibitor presale, public from Sep 21	Maintenance execution: the Navy corrosion event; preservation is a top waterfront cost driver
Nov 2-4, 2027	Indo Pacific 2027 International Maritime Exposition, ICC Sydney, Australia (AMDA Foundation)	Not published yet	Supply chain / policy engagement: the Pacific's naval industry exposition; the allied yards the brief follows exhibit here